

Reasonable Adjustments That Actually Help

From standing desks to flexible hours — what to ask for.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-26 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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From standing desks to flexible hours — what to ask for.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Versus Arthritis consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- **Watch the warning signs.** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/finances\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Multiple systematic reviews of workplace interventions consistently show that a combination of environmental adjustments and flexible work arrangements can significantly reduce pain and improve function for people with various forms of arthritis. These studies, often drawing on data from many smaller trials, highlight that tailored adjustments are more effective than a one-size-fits-all approach. Ergonomic equipment, such as specialised chairs or keyboards, alongside modifications to work tasks, are frequently cited as beneficial.

Clinical guidelines from professional bodies universally recommend that employers make reasonable adjustments to support employees living with long-term conditions like arthritis. These recommendations are based on expert consensus and the accumulated evidence from observational studies and intervention trials. The emphasis is typically on early intervention and ongoing communication between the employee, employer, and healthcare professionals to ensure the adjustments remain appropriate as needs change.

The evidence also points to the importance of a supportive work environment. Beyond physical adjustments, a positive attitude from management and colleagues can play a crucial role in an employee's ability to remain productive and feel valued. Research indicates that psychological support and understanding can reduce stress, which, in turn, may help manage arthritis symptoms.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Not communicating openly with your employer:** They can't help if they don't know what you need. **Fix:** Schedule a meeting to discuss your condition and potential adjustments.* **Waiting until symptoms are severe before asking for help:** Early intervention often prevents problems from escalating. **Fix:** Request adjustments as soon as you notice an impact on your work.* **Asking for generic adjustments without considering your specific needs:** What works for one person might not work for you. **Fix:** Think about your daily tasks and identify specific challenges.* **Focusing only on physical adjustments and ignoring flexible working:** Flexible hours can sometimes be as impactful as a new chair. **Fix:** Explore options like staggered hours or working from home on certain days.* **Feeling guilty about asking for support:** This is about enabling you to do your job well. **Fix:** Remember that reasonable adjustments are a legal right in many workplaces.*

When to Speak to a Clinician

It's always a good idea to keep your healthcare team informed about how your arthritis is affecting you, especially at work. Don't hesitate to reach out if you experience any significant changes or new concerns.

* Sudden increase in joint pain or swelling that isn't settling. * New difficulties with tasks you previously managed well at work. * Changes in your ability to perform daily activities outside of work. * Symptoms that are affecting your sleep or overall mood. * You're feeling overwhelmed or stressed by your work situation due to your arthritis.

Frequently Asked Questions

What kind of documentation do I need to request reasonable adjustments? Often, a letter or report from your general practitioner or specialist outlining your condition and its impact on your work tasks is sufficient. This helps your employer understand your needs and the rationale behind your request.

Can my employer refuse a request for reasonable adjustments? Employers are generally expected to make 'reasonable' adjustments. They can only refuse if an adjustment is deemed unreasonable due to factors like cost, practicality, or business impact. However, they should always explore alternatives with you.

How often should I review my reasonable adjustments? It's a good idea to review your adjustments regularly, perhaps annually, or whenever there's a significant change in your symptoms or job role. Your needs can change over time, and adjustments that worked initially might need updating.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about reasonable adjustments that actually help?

Short answer: Reasonable adjustments for arthritis work best when tailored to your symptoms and job, combining ergonomic equipment, task changes, flexible hours or home working, and a supportive workplace. The article advises early, open communication with employers, regular review as needs change, symptom tracking, and clinician input, especially for new swelling, worsening pain, reduced function, poor sleep, mood changes or stress.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk